

The Cave We Call Ourselves

We fall in love with the people who are willing to share our cave, and we go cold, or defensive, or quietly start arguing, the moment someone tries to walk into it and rearrange the furniture. Not because they're wrong. Because it's our cave.

Every one of us is carrying an operating narrative, built out of everything we've lived through, and that operating narrative is the thing standing between us and the raw, unfiltered chaos of reality. It's shelter. And somewhere along the way, we started treating the difference between shelter and no shelter as the difference between living and dying. Stepping outside the cave doesn't feel like hearing a new idea. It feels like exposure. So we don't leave, and we don't let anyone else walk in uninvited either.

You can see it most clearly in who we're drawn to. We gravitate toward people who are more likely to validate what we already believe, and we get avoidant or defensive around people who reject it or hold up an opposing one. We call this compatibility, or chemistry, or being on the same wavelength. What it actually is, most of the time, is finding someone willing to move into the cave with us and agree not to touch the walls.

Same thing with what we read. We rarely finish a book where the author doesn't validate our premise, and we happily plow through five hundred pages of one that does.

It's not just people who get pulled into the cave with us anymore either. Ask an AI model a question with your own premise already built into it, and it tends to agree hard with whichever side of the truth you've staked out, smoothing past the nuance that would actually complicate your position, because nuance creates friction and friction reads as a worse answer. So you start bringing the model itself into the cave, treating it like the one voice that always gets it, that never makes you defend the wall. That's not an accident either. A model that agrees with you keeps you in the conversation longer, and longer conversations are more data to train the next version on, plus a user who feels understood doesn't go try a different product. The cave used to be something you found other people to share. Now it's something a product can manufacture for you on demand, at scale, and get paid for doing it.

There's a name for what happens when the cave stops being something you retreat into and becomes something you go looking for in other people: projection. You don't just want someone who happens to agree with your operating narrative, you start seeing them through it, painting the shape of your own narrative onto whoever's standing in front of you and mistaking the outline for the person. It feels like recognition, like you've spotted something true about them. Really you've just found a surface good enough to hold the shape you were already carrying.

There are two places this shows up dressed in a suit, where the projection gets a professional name so nobody has to call it what it is.

The first is venture capital. An investor meets a founder and something clicks, the founder reminds them of the last person who returned the fund, or of themselves at that age, or of the exact archetype they've been waiting to back. The investor calls this pattern recognition. It sounds like a skill, like something earned through years of seeing enough deals to spot a signal. Sometimes it is. But a lot of the time what's actually happening is projection wearing a blazer. The investor isn't recognizing a pattern in the founder, they're recognizing a story they already wanted to be true, and the founder happens to be a convenient surface to project it onto. "This one's going to be the next fund returner" isn't a conclusion, it's a wish, dressed up in enough vocabulary to survive a partner meeting.

The second is romance. Someone meets a stranger and something clicks, and they call it chemistry, or compatibility, or say he's exactly what I've always wanted. It's the same mechanism as the VC in the partner meeting, just without the vocabulary to disguise it. You're not seeing the person in front of you. You're seeing the shape their outline makes once you've poured your own fantasy into it, and the fantasy fits so well it feels like recognition instead of invention.

Here's where it gets interesting, and where both of these caves reveal the same crack. Investors will tell you, often proudly, that they want founders who can be vulnerable with them. Founders can show us the real numbers, the real doubt, we'll stay with them till the end. Romantic partners say almost the identical thing in a different accent. I just want a man who's emotionally available, who can actually open up. Both are sincere when they say it. And both, when the real thing shows up, panic.

Because what they actually wanted wasn't vulnerability. It was a curated, on-brand version of vulnerability that still fits the story they'd already projected. A founder admitting "I made a mistake in the last quarter, but I've already fixed the process" reads as growth, and slots neatly into the visionary narrative. A founder admitting "I genuinely don't know if this works, and some nights I think it won't" doesn't slot in anywhere. It's not the vulnerability the investor asked for, it's the raw kind, the kind that exposes uncertainty instead of resolving it into a better story, and it threatens the exact fund-returner narrative the investor had already started telling their own partners.

Same with the woman asking why he isn't showing vulnerability, and then, the one time he actually does, quietly pulling back and wondering what happened to the confident man she met. What happened is he stopped performing the vulnerability that fit her cave and showed her the kind that doesn't, the uncertain, unglamorous, un-prince-charming kind, and her nervous system read it as the walls shifting.

This connects straight back to the gap I wrote about in “the stories we say ourselves.” Both the investor and the romantic partner have a spoken narrative, the one they say out loud, we welcome vulnerability, we want the real you. And both are running a completely different operating narrative underneath it, the one that only shows up the moment reality actually tests it. Stripped of the professional vocabulary and the romantic vocabulary, here's what those two operating narratives actually say:

I love the version of you that fits into my mental model of safety, attraction, and morality.

I backed the version of you that validates my fund thesis, calms my partner anxiety, and lets me feel like a visionary without risking my reputation.

Neither the investor nor the partner is lying when they ask for vulnerability. They just don't know yet that what they're asking for is a specific, pre-approved shape of it, one that confirms the cave rather than exposing it. Real vulnerability doesn't come pre-approved. It comes as evidence that the story you'd built about this person, and often the story you'd built about your own judgment for choosing them, might be wrong. That's not a small ask. That's the walls coming down.

I know I might have simplified this too much, drawing a straight line between boardroom dynamics and romance. This is where it actually diverges, in my opinion. Investors aren't soldiers, whatever the pitch deck language implies. They're risk-hedgers and capital allocators, people whose actual job is to price your uncertainty and get comfortable enough with the number to write a check. That's a different relationship than the one you have with a partner. A partner is choosing to live inside your uncertainty with you. An investor is choosing to be exposed to it, at arm's length, in exchange for a return.

That difference changes what vulnerability is even for in each room. In romance, radical vulnerability isn't a risk you take on top of the relationship, it's the mechanism the relationship runs on. Fake it and you don't get a safer version of the same closeness, you get the shape of a relationship with nothing inside it, two people performing intimacy at each other on a loop. There's no curated, lesser version of that connection that still works. The vulnerability isn't the cost of the closeness. It is the closeness.

In venture, or in running anything people have put money into, it's closer to the opposite. The founder's actual job is to absorb uncertainty on behalf of everyone downstream, the team, the investors, eventually the market, and hand back something closer to clarity. That's not dishonesty, it's the function. A surgeon doesn't share their private doubt about the technique mid-incision, not because they don't have any, but because the doubt isn't useful to you right then, your job is to trust the hands, not audit the internal monologue running behind them. Pipe raw, uncurated panic into a boardroom or a public market and you haven't been honest, you've handed your unmanaged uncertainty to a system that was never built to hold it, and it

reacts exactly like any system does when you feed it more volatility than it can absorb. It marks you down. It walks.

So the asymmetry isn't about which room hurts more when it goes wrong, both can genuinely wreck you. It's about what each room is actually built to do with what you hand it. A partner who can't hold your vulnerability costs you a relationship. An investor who catches your unmanaged panic costs you the company. Know which room you're standing in before you decide how much of the cave to open up.

Everything up to here has been about who you let into the cave. There's a second question sitting underneath it that matters just as much: what the cave is actually built to keep out. Because a cave isn't automatically the villain of this essay. It's just a structure, and a structure can be load-bearing or it can be a trap, depending entirely on what it was built to hold back.

Up to this point, the cave sounds entirely like a pathology, a blind spot to untangle, an instinct to manage, a defensive reflex that sabotages relationships and corrupts cap tables. But that's only half the truth. A cave isn't inherently a vice, it's an instrument. Total imperviousness to the outside world is the exact same trait that builds world-altering breakthroughs and the same trait that builds historic catastrophes.

Two people can run the exact same strategy, total conviction, complete deafness to outside doubt, and end up on opposite ends of history, depending entirely on what that conviction was actually defending against.

Take Jensen Huang. For years he ran Nvidia on a thesis Wall Street had no patience for, pouring billions into CUDA and parallel computing hardware while the quarterly numbers people wanted a return that hadn't shown up yet. He walled off the skepticism entirely, didn't argue with it, didn't seek its approval, just treated it as noise outside a cave built around a specific read on how computing was going to work. That's strategic ignorance doing exactly what it's supposed to do. The cave wasn't protecting him from reality. It was protecting an accurate read on reality from a market that hadn't caught up to it yet. He was hiding from opinion, not from physics.

Now take Elizabeth Holmes. Same architecture. Total conviction, total imperviousness, every skeptic reframed as someone who just hadn't caught up to the vision yet. But what she was walling out wasn't consensus opinion, it was microfluidics, chemistry, the actual physical limits of what a drop of blood can tell you. Huang's cave sheltered a thesis about the future that turned out to be true. Holmes's cave sheltered a claim about the present that was never going to be true no matter how long she refused to look at it.

That's the actual test for whether a cave is an asset or a coffin. Ask what it's built to keep out. If it's keeping out the crowd, the noise, the people who need you to be legible on their timeline

instead of yours, it can be the thing that lets you finish work nobody else had the patience to fund. If it's keeping out the lab result, the engineer telling you it doesn't work yet, the physics that doesn't care how solidified your narrative is, it's not conviction anymore. It's just a very well-decorated way of running out of time.